regulation could not stand absent a showing of a compelling state interest. *Id.*, at 786.[1]

The First and Fourteenth Amendments guarantee that no State shall "abridg[e] the freedom of speech." See *Joseph Burstyn, Inc.* v. *Wilson,* 343 U. S. 495, 500–501 (1952). Freedom of speech is "indispensable to the discovery and spread of political truth," *Whitney* v. *California,* 274 U. S. 357, 375 (1927) (Brandeis, J., concurring), and "the best test of truth is the power of the thought to get itself accepted in the competition of the market. . . ." *Abrams* v. *United States,* 250 U. S. 616, 630 (1919) (Holmes, J., dissenting).[2] The First and Fourteenth Amendments remove "governmental restraints from the arena of public discussion, putting the decision as to what views shall be voiced largely into the hands of each of us, in the hope that use of such freedom will ultimately produce a more capable citizenry and more perfect polity. . . ." *Cohen* v. *California,* 403 U. S. 15, 24 (1971).[3]

This Court has emphasized that the First Amendment "embraces at the least the liberty to discuss publicly and truthfully all matters of public concern. . . ." *Thornhill* v.

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[1] Nor does Consolidated Edison's status as a privately owned but government regulated monopoly preclude its assertion of First Amendment rights. See *Central Hudson Gas & Electric Corp.* v. *Public Service Comm'n, post,* at 566–568. We have recognized that the speech of heavily regulated businesses may enjoy constitutional protection. See, *e. g., Friedman* v. *Rogers,* 440 U. S. 1 (1979); *Virginia Pharmacy Board* v. *Virginia Citizens Consumer Council,* 425 U. S. 748, 763–765 (1976). Consolidated Edison's position as a regulated monopoly does not decrease the informative value of its opinions on critical public matters. See generally *Public Media Center* v. *FCC,* 190 U. S. App. D. C. 425, 428, 429, 587 F. 2d 1322, 1325, 1326 (1978); *Pacific Gas & Electric Co.* v. *City of Berkeley,* 60 Cal. App. 3d 123, 127–129, 131 Cal. Rptr. 350, 352–353 (1976).

[2] Freedom of speech also protects the individual's interest in self-expression. *First National Bank of Boston* v. *Bellotti,* 435 U. S. 765, 777, n. 12 (1978); see T. Emerson, The System of Freedom of Expression 6 (1970).

[3] See also A. Meiklejohn, Political Freedom 35–36 (1965).